

Windows 10 End of Life FAQ for Small to Medium-Sized Businesses

Updated: July 2025

Frequently Asked Questions

- 1. What are the risks of continuing to use Windows 10 after its End of Life on October 14, 2025?** After the End of Life, Windows 10 will no longer receive security updates, increasing vulnerability to cyberattacks such as malware and data breaches. For small to medium-sized businesses, this could result in data loss, non-compliance with regulations (e.g., GDPR, HIPAA), and reputational harm. Upgrading to a supported operating system or enrolling in Extended Security Updates (ESUs) is essential to protect business operations.
- 2. What happens when Windows 10 reaches its End of Life?** After October 14, 2025, Microsoft will discontinue security patches, feature updates, and technical support for Windows 10. This leaves business systems exposed to security risks and unsupported for critical applications, potentially disrupting operations.
- 3. How can I prepare my business for the Windows 10 End of Life?** Businesses should audit their IT environment to identify Windows 10 devices, using tools like Lansweeper, back up critical data, and plan upgrades to Windows 11 or alternative systems. Verify hardware compatibility, budget for upgrades, and train staff to ensure a smooth transition with minimal disruption.
- 4. Why are businesses shifting to Windows 11 before the Windows 10 End of Life?** Windows 11 is gaining traction, with a 30.48% business market share as of January 2025, due to its inclusion on new devices and improved stability. For businesses, upgrading ensures continued security, software compatibility, and access to Microsoft support, enhancing productivity.
- 5. How do I upgrade to Windows 11?** Eligible devices can be upgraded to Windows 11 using the Windows Update tool or by downloading the installer from Microsoft's official website. Ensure hardware meets requirements (e.g., TPM 2.0, Secure Boot) to avoid compatibility issues that could impact business workflows.
- 6. What should I do if my hardware isn't compatible with Windows 11?** If devices don't support Windows 11, options include enrolling in the paid Extended Security Updates program for up to three years, switching to a Linux distribution for a cost-free solution, or purchasing new compatible hardware. Always back up data before making changes.

7. **Can I get free security updates for Windows 10 after its End of Life?** Microsoft offers free security updates until October 2026 for users with a Microsoft account, accessible via Settings or notifications. Without an account, businesses can pay \$30 or use 1,000 Microsoft Rewards points for ESUs, providing a temporary security solution.
8. **What are Extended Security Updates (ESUs)?** ESUs are a paid Microsoft service providing security updates for select Windows 10 Enterprise editions for up to three years after the End of Life. This is a costly but viable option for businesses to extend the life of critical systems while planning upgrades.
9. **Can I continue using Windows 10 after support ends?** Although possible, Microsoft advises against using Windows 10 post-EOL due to significant security risks. For businesses, continuing without updates could compromise sensitive data and client trust, making upgrades or ESUs a priority.
10. **Is my older PC compatible with Windows 11?** Older hardware may not meet Windows 11s requirements (e.g., 4GB RAM, 64-bit processor). If incompatible, businesses must consider the cost of new devices versus temporary solutions like ESUs or Linux to maintain operational security.
11. **Can I switch to Linux after Windows 10 support ends?** Linux is a free, secure alternative to Windows, ideal for businesses with older hardware. Distributions like Ubuntu can extend device lifespans, but businesses should evaluate software compatibility and staff training needs for a smooth transition.
12. **What is the Windows 10 Long-Term Servicing Channel (LTSC), and how does its lifecycle differ?** Windows 10 LTSC, used by some businesses for stable environments, receives extended support beyond October 14, 2025, depending on the release. Businesses using LTSC should consult Microsofts lifecycle documentation to confirm support dates for their edition.